Subscription model: questions for the Product Manager

Prepared 2026-10-10 for the product manager. Goal: decide **how many subscription plans we keep, what each plan contains, what each costs, and what happens at the limits**, so engineering can build plan gating, metering and billing once instead of three times.

How to use this document. Every question has (a) what the product does today, (b) a recommended default, and (c) an `Answer:` line. If you agree with the default, write "Agree". Items marked **BLOCKER** stop engineering work on plan limits.
Numbers in the "recommended" lines are starting points to react to, not validated prices. Where I say "today" it was verified in the code or the database on 2026-10-10.

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1. What exists today

1.1 Employer plans (database table `subscription_plans`, prices stored in paise)

Plan	Price	Active jobs	Recruiter seats	Resume access	Candidate search limit	Features JSON
`free`	Rs 0	1	1	no	10	empty
`standard` (monthly)	Rs 1,999 / mo	5	5	yes	100	empty
`standard_annual`	Rs 19,990 / yr	5	5	yes	100	empty
`premium` (monthly)	Rs 4,999 / mo	20	15	yes	500	empty
`premium_annual`	Rs 49,990 / yr	20	15	yes	500	empty
`enterprise`	Rs 0 (custom)	unlimited	unlimited	yes	unlimited	empty

1.2 Aspirant (candidate) plans

Plan	Price	Notes
`aspirant_free`	Rs 0	3 uses of each premium feature (`FREE_TIER_LIMIT`): AI counsellor chat, roadmap, resume builder, practice mock interview
`aspirant_premium_monthly`	Rs 299 / mo	unlocks the four gated features

Plan	Price	Notes
`aspirant_premium_annual`	Rs 2,990 / yr	same

1.3 What is actually enforced in code today

- **Enforced:** active job count (`max_active_jobs`), recruiter seats (`max_recruiter_seats`), subscription must be "active" to use the dashboard, aspirant free-tier counters.
- **Shown but, as far as I could find, not enforced:** `resume_access` and `candidate_search_limit` (no code path checks them outside display).
- **Not present at all:** any limit, meter or price for **AI interviews**, department limits, storage, number of applicants, data-export, support level, SLA.
- **Payments:** Razorpay is integrated for plan checkout, but the `razorpay_plan_id` column is **empty on every plan** and the Razorpay keys are blank in the dev config, so paid checkout has not been proven end to end for employers. Needs a live test.

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2. Questions

A. Business model and customers

A1. Who is the paying customer in the first 12 months? (small employers hiring a few roles, mid-size HR teams, large enterprises, staffing agencies, institutes/NGOs/think-tanks?)
Recommended: small and mid-size employers hiring in policy, research, public affairs, CSR, ed-tech; enterprise only by quote.

> **Answer:**

A2. Which revenue streams do we want? Options: employer subscriptions, pay-per-use AI interviews, candidate subscriptions (aspirant premium), job-posting fees, featured listings, placement fees, data/API access.
Recommended: employer subscription (core) + metered AI interviews (add-on usage) + aspirant premium (existing). No placement fees until pilot data exists.

> **Answer:**

A3. Is the aspirant (candidate) side a revenue line or a supply-side growth tool? This decides whether we keep charging candidates Rs 299/mo.

> **Answer:**

A4. Which countries do we sell in during year one? (India only, or also other countries.) This changes tax, invoicing, currency and the legal workload.
Recommended: India only, INR, GST invoices.

Answer:

B. How many employer plans, and what is in each (BLOCKER)

B1. How many employer tiers do we want? Today: Free, Standard, Premium, Enterprise (4) plus annual variants.
Recommended: keep **4 tiers** (Free, Standard, Premium, Enterprise) with monthly and annual billing (annual = about 2 months free). Fewer tiers make the AI interview quota easier to explain.

Answer:

B2. Fill in the plan matrix. The proposed starting values are below. For each cell, confirm or change. Cells marked `?` have no value today and need a decision.

	Free	Standard	Premium	Enterprise
Monthly price	Rs 0	Rs 1,999	Rs 4,999	custom
Annual price	n/a	Rs 19,990	Rs 49,990	custom
Active jobs	1	5	20	unlimited
Recruiter seats	1	5	15	custom
Departments	`?` (1)	`?` (3)	`?` (10)	unlimited
Applicants per job per month	`?` (50)	`?` (500)	`?` (unlimited)	unlimited
Resume access	no	yes	yes	yes
Candidate search / talent pool views per month	10	100	500	custom
AI interviews included per month	`?` (5, text only)	`?` (25)	`?` (100)	`?` (contract)
AI interview overage price per extra interview	not available	`?` (Rs 49)	`?` (Rs 39)	contract
AI interview modes	text	text + audio answers	text + audio answers	+ live voice later
Employer-approved question sets / templates	1	5	unlimited	unlimited
Auto-invite candidates after applying	no	no	yes	yes
Bulk invitations	no	up to 25 at once	up to 200	unlimited
Team/department-scoped access	no	yes	yes	yes
Data retention of candidate results	180 days	180 days	365 days (configurable)	custom
CSV/PDF export of scorecards	no	yes	yes	yes

	Free	Standard	Premium	Enterprise
ATS / API / webhook integration	no	no	? (webhook)	yes
Support	email	email	priority email + chat	dedicated manager, SLA
SSO / audit log export	no	no	no	yes

Answer (changes to the table):

B3. Should AI interviews be a separate paid add-on rather than bundled in plans?
Options: (1) bundled allowance + overage (recommended), (2) separate "AI Interviewer" subscription on top of any plan, (3) pure pay-per-interview with no allowance.

Answer:

B4. Should the Free plan include any AI interviews? A small allowance (about 5 per month, text-only, 1 active screen) lets a small employer try the real product, but each interview costs us money (see the AI document, cost section).
Recommended: yes, 5 per month, hard cap, one free account per verified company.

Answer:

C. AI interview pricing mechanics (BLOCKER)

C1. What counts as one billable "AI interview"?
Recommended: one candidate's interview that was **completed and scored**. Not charged: invitations that expired/declined, system failures, the free technical-failure retake, employer test runs.

Answer:

C2. Do unused interviews roll over to next month?
Recommended: no rollover for included allowance; purchased packs are valid 12 months.

Answer:

C3. What happens when an employer reaches the limit?
Options: (a) block new invitations with an upgrade prompt, (b) allow automatic overage billing up to a monthly ceiling the employer sets, (c) allow buying a prepaid pack.
Recommended: block at 100% unless the employer has enabled overage or bought a pack; warn at 80%.

Answer:

C4. Overage and pack prices. Proposed Rs 49 per extra interview on Standard, Rs 39 on Premium; packs of 25 and 100.
Estimated cost to us is about Rs 10-20 per interview on cheap models (not measured; see the AI document), so these keep a healthy margin. Confirm or change.

Answer:

C5. Do we reserve (hold) an interview credit at invitation time or only consume it on completion? Recommended: reserve at invitation (so the employer cannot over-invite), release on expiry/decline/cancel, consume on scoring.

Answer:

D. Free plan and abuse protection

D1. How do we stop one company from creating many free accounts? (company verification/KYC, GST/CIN check, domain email, phone, manual review.)
Recommended: require verified company (existing KYC flow) before any free AI interviews are available.

Answer:

D2. Trial. Do paid plans get a free trial (e.g. 14 days) or a money-back guarantee?

Answer:

E. Billing operations

E1. Billing intervals: monthly and annual only, or also quarterly?

Answer:

E2. Upgrades and downgrades: pro-rated immediately, or at the next billing date? What happens to jobs/seats/AI interview allowance above the new plan's limit after a downgrade? (Recommended: keep existing data readable, block creating new items above the limit, 30-day grace.)

Answer:

E3. Failed payment and cancellation: grace period before access is restricted (recommended 7 days), and what is restricted (new jobs and new AI invitations yes, viewing existing results no).

Answer:

E4. Refund policy (monthly, annual, unused AI interviews).

Answer:

E5. Taxes and invoices: GST rate and GSTIN on invoices, invoice emails, credit notes. Who handles this (existing payments module, accountant)?

Answer:

E6. Payment methods: cards, UPI, netbanking, invoice/bank transfer for enterprise? Razorpay only?

Answer:

E7. Company details needed at checkout (billing name, address, GSTIN).

Answer:

F. Limits and how strictly we enforce them

F1. For each limit (jobs, seats, departments, applicants, AI interviews, searches): hard block, soft warning, or overage? Recommended: jobs, seats, departments, AI interviews = hard block with upgrade prompt; searches = hard block; applicants = soft warning.

Answer:

F2. Who can see usage and billing? Owner only, or also HR managers? (Recommended: owner and admins see billing; department heads see their own usage.)

Answer:

F3. Should AI-interview usage be shared across the company or limited per department?

Answer:

G. Enterprise

G1. What does Enterprise include and who sells it? (Custom contract, SSO, data processing agreement, SLA, audit export, custom retention, dedicated support, higher limits.) Is there a minimum annual commitment?

Answer:

G2. Do we allow white-labelling or custom branding of the candidate interview page?

Answer:

H. Aspirant plans

H1. Keep Rs 299/mo and Rs 2,990/yr? Do we keep the "3 free uses" per feature?

Answer:

H2. Can an employer's AI interview use candidate practice data? (Recommended: no. Employer interviews must be independent of practice history.)

Answer:

H3. Do candidates ever pay for employer-requested interviews? (Recommended: never.)

Answer:

I. Legal and policy

I1. Who writes the subscription terms, refund policy and the AI-interview terms of use? Needs a lawyer before launch.

Answer:

I2. Is there a contractual commitment about AI accuracy or fairness? (Recommended: no accuracy guarantees; documented limitations and human decision-making only.)

Answer:

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3. Suggested decision order

1. B1-B2 (tiers and matrix), 2. C1-C4 (AI pricing), 3. D1, 4. E2-E3, 5. everything else.
   Once B2, C1, C3 and C4 are answered, engineering can build plan gating, usage metering and checkout in about 2-3 weeks (estimate).